Pir Panjal and Shamsabari ranges in the south and west. It has been one of the cradles of the Indian civilization since early days, and evolved as a homogenous 'melange' of Brahmanism, Buddhism, Islam, Sikhism and Sufism.



Panorama 11.1: Vale of Kashmir (Courtesy: Shanta Serbjeet Singh).

The ruins of the magnificent ancient temples at Martand, Harwan and Awantipur, which your ancestors built centuries ago and which have been described in the scriptures, reveal the greatness of your culture. Those huge blocks of granite didn't fall from the skies. So how can you forget your history, beliefs and way of life, particularly the spirit of Kashmiriyat derived from the philosophy propounded by famous saints like Sheikh Noor-ud-Din or Nund Rishi? He was also known as 'Allamdar-e-Kashmir', and is regarded by all of you as the patron saint of Kashmir. History tells us that your forefathers embraced Islam around the twelfth century. Therefore, you cannot disown your ancestors whose blood flows in your veins and your heritage.

Despite the imperfections we are a vibrant democracy. You have been participating in the election process for over four decades. Why don't the leaders of the jehadis stand for